



Ready to be tried

Lieutenant Calley leaves a preliminary hearing on August 24, 1970, with a civilian attorney and a military escort. Calley's court martial was a general court martial—the most serious court of military trial—for which a preliminary Article 32 hearing is mandatory.

Lack of justice

At the end of the trial, only Calley was convicted—for personally killing 22 villagers. Despite an initial life sentence for premeditated murder, the lieutenant served only three months in military prison and three and a half years under house arrest. Nixon reduced the sentence under public pressure from those who saw Calley as a scapegoat for the failures of the Army.

The media coverage and trials brought public attention to the massacre and raised serious issues about the conduct of the war. Were the men of this company defective, or was the entire war defective? The military prosecutors, Aubrey Daniel and William Eckhardt, claimed that politics interfered with the army's ability to bring the perpetrators to justice.